Sycamore Square — Engineering Review and City Pre-Application Package

Public version · 18 Oct 2026

Purpose

This package asks a licensed engineering firm to confirm the concept plans, and the City of Memphis to say at a pre-application meeting what approvals the plan needs. The drawings come from county GIS data and the building's 1997 tenant plans, not a survey. They show what the owners intend to build and where the open questions are. They are not construction, permit or conveyance documents.

The plan turns the existing 127,634 SF single-story building at 1699–1735 Sycamore View Road into five parts:

- Two event halls, Hall A and Hall B, with kitchens and a shared dining room
- A kids' recreation center
- Small-shop retail
- Flex space
- An optional fuel station with a convenience store on the frontage

We need three things from this round:

1. **From the engineers:** a fee proposal and a short written review that confirms or corrects the layout, flood strategy, parking and site access.
2. **From the City:** the approval path for each use and each parcel, the flood rules that apply, and the studies the City will require.
3. **From both:** a list of anything that would stop the plan or change its cost by more than 10%.

Site and building facts

Every fact below needs confirmation by survey, title or the City. The confidence column says how far each one can be trusted today.

Item	What we have	Source	Confidence
Parcels	088066 00027 (9.533 ac, main building), 00020 (5800 Summer, 1.353 ac), 00021 (5810 Summer, 0.476 ac), 00024 (1717 Sycamore View frontage, 0.362 ac). Assessor total 11.72 ac, matching the broker. The county GIS polygons sum to about 11.88 ac; the survey settles it.	Shelby County Assessor 2026; county GIS parcel layer, Oct 2026	Medium (official record) until ALTA survey
Site area	11.72 ac on the assessor record, matching the broker's 11.72 ac. The county GIS polygons sum to about 11.88 ac. The ALTA survey settles the difference.	Shelby County Assessor 2026; offering memorandum; county GIS	Medium (official record) until ALTA survey
Excluded neighbors	Family Dollar (1745 Sycamore View) and the brick retail building (5828 Summer). No work is shown on either.	County GIS; site visit photos	High

Item	What we have	Source	Confidence
Building	127,634 SF listed by the broker; 125,235 SF on the assessor record (built 1984, class office/mixed-use, grade C); ~132,600 SF drawn footprint; single story, height not yet verified; renovated 1996–97	Offering memorandum; Shelby County Assessor 2026; county GIS	Medium
Structure	Area A (south) columns on a ~44.5 × 44.5 ft grid, two of them inside each hall main room; 1-hour rated wall about 270 ft north of the south wall	1997 Sitel tenant plans, sheets A2.1 and A2.2	Medium: ±10 ft, field check needed
Fire protection	Sprinkler riser room on the west wall of Area A	1997 Sitel plans	Medium
Zoning	CMU-3 on 00027, 00020 and 00021; residential and agricultural zoning behind the building to the west	County GIS zoning layer	Medium; 00024 not yet confirmed
Flood	FEMA Zone AE from Fletcher Creek, FIRM panel 47157C0311G, effective 6 Feb 2013. About 74% of the footprint is in Zone AE and the rest in shaded Zone X; no floodway on the site. About 4.0 ac of the site fall in the city flood layer. Base flood elevation (BFE) lines next to the building read 248 ft NAVD88. USGS 1 m lidar (2017) puts the ground at 250–252 ft along ~85% of the walls and 247.7–248.8 ft along ~240 ft of the rear (west) truck-dock area.	FEMA National Flood Hazard Layer, queried 18 Oct 2026; USGS lidar via EPQS; city flood layer copy	High for map data; floor elevation needs a survey
Former use on frontage	2,086 SF "mini lube" building, built 1981, recorded on 00024 in the 2017 county flight. Demolished under permit DEM-24-000379 (31 Oct 2024), with its foundation and footings removed.	County planimetrics; demolition permit DEM-24-000379	High that it existed and was demolished; subsurface unknown
Parking	909 spaces claimed by the broker; ~769 counted from GIS paint lines	Offering memorandum; county planimetrics	Low until counted on site
Roads and traffic	Sycamore View 30,226, Summer Ave (US-70) 21,290, Pleasant View 10,064 vehicles a day. TDOT is widening Summer Avenue from I-40 to east of Sycamore View, including the Fletcher Creek bridge, June 2025–June 2028.	Offering memorandum (counts); TDOT, Summer Avenue widening	Low for the counts (dates and sources not given); High for the widening
Utilities	800 kW generator: unverified listing claim, not in the offering memorandum or teaser; utility sizes unknown	Online listing only	Low
Sale	Offered by Ten-X online auction, 2–4 Nov 2026; 0% occupied.	Auction teaser (updated)	High

Proposed program

The whole existing building is reused and its outer walls do not move. A new 4,000 SF convenience store is the only new building, and it is optional. Areas are gross planning budgets; net usable areas come after a measured interior survey.

Part	Gross area	What it contains
Hall A suite	20,563 SF	11,000 SF main room (132 × 83 ft between column lines; its 2 existing interior columns are to be removed with transfer girders), foyer with its own entrance from the east lot, two 700 SF family suites, guest toilets

Part	Gross area	What it contains
Hall B suite	17,009 SF	Same 11,000 SF main room (its 2 interior columns also removed) and suites; own entrance on the south-facing wall of its foyer, reached from the south lot; own toilets
Kitchens	3,895 SF	Two ~1,950 SF catering kitchens, one per hall, each with rear receiving; a controlled door lets one caterer run both
Dining and gallery	4,484 SF	2,400 SF reservable dining room plus a guest gallery linking the two foyers
Service support	1,779 SF	Storage, staff, janitorial
Kids' recreation	18,000 SF	Public play and party rooms with their own entrance, plus a private zone reached from Hall A
Retail	35,000 SF	20–25 storefronts along the north and east walls
Flex	26,904 SF	Shell held in reserve with its own west entrance
Building total	**127,634 SF**	Matches the listed floor area
C-store (optional, new)	4,000 SF	80 × 50 ft store

The halls run three ways. One family can book Hall A and Hall B together for a single wedding, with guests split between two rooms. Two unrelated events can run at once, each with its own entrance, kitchen and staff. Or both halls can open to each other as one coordinated event.

Separate arrivals. Hall A guests arrive from the east lot through the east façade. Hall B guests arrive from the south lot through the south-facing wall of the B foyer. The two arrivals are on separate façades, so two events can arrive at the same time without crossing paths.

Column-free main rooms. Each 11,000 SF main room has 2 existing roof columns (1997 drawings, about 44.5 ft grid). The owners want column-free rooms, so the plan removes all four with steel transfer girders of about 88 ft span. The structural question below asks whether that works and what it costs.

Fuel has two candidate locations; no decision is made yet.

- **F1, frontage (preferred):** a 72 × 40 ft canopy with six fueling positions and a 40 × 20 ft tank area on the 1717 frontage, about 91 ft from Sycamore View. It is reached from the existing throat drive, and the store sits beside it on the main parcel. It sits on the former quick-lube pad.
- **F2, 5800 Summer (fallback):** store and canopy as one block on the pad parcel beside Summer Avenue, outside the city flood layer as drawn; confirm against FEMA's map.
- **No fuel:** the frontage stays parking and landscaping.

Layout alternative under study

An alternative layout is under study with the halls at the north end of the building and the shops at the south end. In it, Hall A enters from the north lot off Pleasant View Road and Hall B from the east lot, and the kids' center sits between the halls and the shops. It uses the same program and the same gross areas. It is shown on sheets ALT-1 to ALT-3 in a separate PDF, Sycamore_Square_Alternative_Layout_Halls_North.pdf.

We ask the engineers and the City to comment on both layouts, in particular on:

- parking and access for evening events on Pleasant View Road
- the residential edge to the west of the site
- fire access to both hall entrances

Questions for the engineering team

The flood answers come first, because the 50% rule can decide the whole budget. Each row names what we want back.

Discipline	Question	What we want back
Survey	What are the true boundary, easements, encroachments and acreage of the four parcels? Do any recorded access or parking agreements bind the site?	ALTA/NSPS survey with Table A items 1–4, 6–11, 13, 16–19
Survey and flood	The BFE lines next to the building read 248 ft, so the design floor is 250 ft (BFE + 24 in, UDC 8.8). Does the finished floor meet 250 ft? What is the FEMA-profile BFE at the rear wall, and the lowest adjacent grade at the dock wells?	FEMA elevation certificate
Flood	A LOMA uses the lowest adjacent grade, not the floor (44 CFR 65.5), and the rear dock area sits at 247.7–248.8 ft. Is a LOMA achievable, or should the building show compliance by elevation instead? If neither works, can it be dry-floodproofed to the level the City requires, and at what cost?	Written flood strategy with a cost range
Flood	How will improvement cost and structure value be counted for the 50% substantial-improvement test, and does Memphis count improvements over several years?	Memo agreed with the floodplain administrator
Structural	Each hall main room has 2 existing roof columns (about 44.5 ft grid). Can all four be removed with steel transfer girders of about 88 ft span? What is the roof framing type? Can the end columns and their footings take the added load? What clear height remains under the new girders? What temporary shoring is needed? What is the price per column removed? The cost is budgeted in the feasibility study. Precedents: Tulsa WeStreet Ice Center, Christ Church of Northwest Arkansas, Chelsea Piers Connecticut and Eagle Brook Church (Anoka, MN).	Feasibility letter and budget
Structural	Can the roof carry new rooftop units, kitchen hoods and any rigging loads? What is the clear height?	Roof framing check and field measurements
Structural (earthquake code)	Under the 2021 IBC, which Shelby County uses, assembly rooms of more than 300 people each that together exceed 2,500 occupants put a building in Risk Category III. A change of occupancy that raises the Risk Category can require the existing building to meet current seismic requirements (IEBC §1006.3). The exception for changes under 10% of the building area does not help here: the halls are about 17% of the building. Memphis is near the New Madrid fault, so this could cost more than the column work. With table-and-chair layouts the two halls hold about 1,470 people, which is under the line; chairs-only ceremony seating would cross it, and the playground and dining can count too. What is the site's seismic design value (SDS)? Does capping each hall's posted capacity keep the building in Risk Category II? Are the interior columns part of the lateral system?	Risk Category determination, the site's SDS, the posted-capacity cap that keeps Risk Category II, and the scope and cost of any seismic upgrade
Architectural and code	What are the occupancy groups and occupant loads? How many exits and toilets do the halls, play center and retail need, and what fire separations? Does the 1-hour wall stay useful?	Code analysis and a measured floor plan
Fire protection	Can the existing sprinkler system be extended or does it need replacement? Is a fire pump needed? What fire alarm is required for assembly use?	Sprinkler and alarm narrative with a budget

Discipline	Question	What we want back
Mechanical, electrical, plumbing	Is electrical service big enough for two kitchens, a play center and retail? Is there a working generator, and can it be reused? Is there enough sewer and grease-interceptor capacity?	MEP condition report
Civil	How many legal parking spaces are there? The site is very likely in the Fletcher Creek Overlay (UDC 8.9), where staff reports call detention mandatory (S 15-012, P.D. 21-22). Does repaving with no new impervious area trigger it? What repaving is needed? A new c-store would need its floor 30 in above the BFE.	Parking count, drainage memo and civil budget
Traffic	Do the driveways work for peak event arrivals and fuel trucks? Does Summer Avenue (US-70) access need a TDOT permit? Is a traffic study needed?	Trip-generation report and access memo
Environmental	Did the former quick-lube leave tanks, oil or contamination on the frontage?	Phase I ESA (ASTM E1527-21); Phase II if flagged
Fuel (if pursued)	Do the F1 or F2 layouts work for setbacks, canopy clearance, tank placement, tanker turning and queuing?	Fuel site plan from the engineer or fuel operator

Questions for the City pre-application meeting

We want each answer in writing, in the meeting notes or a follow-up letter. Ask Memphis and Shelby County Division of Planning and Development (DPD) to bring zoning, City Engineering, the floodplain administrator, Fire and Building (Construction Code Enforcement) staff to one meeting. Ask TDOT separately about Summer Avenue.

Department	Question	Answer we need
Zoning (DPD)	Are event / banquet halls, indoor recreation, retail, restaurants, supervised child care and fuel sales allowed by right in CMU-3? Which need a special use permit or a planned development?	Use-by-use list, and a zoning verification letter for each parcel
Zoning (DPD)	What zoning applies to the 1717 frontage (00024)? Is any planned-development overlay recorded on the site?	Zoning letter for 00024
Zoning (DPD)	What landscape buffer, screening, setbacks and lighting rules apply along the residential edge to the west?	Code sections and widths
Zoning (DPD)	How many parking spaces do the halls, play center and retail need? Is a shared-parking reduction allowed when the uses peak at different times?	Required count and the reduction method
Zoning (DPD)	Can the uses be approved through Administrative Site Plan Review, or does the project go to the Land Use Control Board? How long does each route take?	The approval route and a timeline
Zoning (DPD)	Can 5800 and 5810 Summer be sold or financed separately as they stand, or is a plat needed?	Yes / no, with the process
Zoning (DPD)	Is the 2025–26 code update likely to change any of these answers before we apply?	Staff view and the adoption date
Floodplain administrator	FEMA's map shows a base flood elevation of 248 ft next to the building. Is the required nonresidential floor or floodproofing level therefore 250 ft (24 inches above BFE under UDC 8.8)? Does the Fletcher Creek Overlay (UDC 8.9) require any new structure, such as the c-store, to sit 30 inches above the BFE?	Confirmed design elevations for the building and any new structure

Department	Question	Answer we need
Floodplain administrator	How is the 50% substantial-improvement test applied here: which costs count, which value is used, and over what period?	Written method
City Engineering	The site is in the Fletcher Creek basin, a sensitive drainage basin, and very likely in the Fletcher Creek Overlay (UDC 8.9). Staff reports in the basin call detention mandatory (S 15-012, P.D. 21-22). Is detention required for repaving and site work on the existing paved lot, with no new impervious area?	Detention yes / no, and whether the overlay applies
City Engineering and Traffic	Are new or changed curb cuts on Sycamore View acceptable? Is a traffic study needed for the event peak?	Access feedback and study scope
Fire Marshal	What fire lanes, hydrants and fire flow do assembly use and a fuel canopy need?	Access and water requirements
Building (Construction Code Enforcement)	Which building code edition applies to the change of use? Will the City accept phased permits (shell, then each tenant)?	Code edition and permit sequence
Building (Construction Code Enforcement)	Will the change to assembly use put the building in Risk Category III under the 2021 IBC (assembly rooms of more than 300 people each, together over 2,500 occupants)? If so, does IEBC §1006.3 require the existing building to meet current seismic requirements, given that the halls are about 17% of the building? Will the City accept a posted capacity for each hall, set so the building stays in Risk Category II?	The Risk Category the City will apply, and whether a posted-capacity cap is accepted
TDOT	Does any driveway work on Summer Avenue (US-70) need a state permit? How does TDOT's Summer Avenue widening (I-40 to east of Sycamore View, June 2025–June 2028) affect driveways for 5800 and 5810 Summer and the F2 fuel layout?	Permit yes / no, the contact, and the widening's effect on access
Health Department	What does each catering kitchen need for a food permit, and what grease-interceptor size?	Permit requirements

Drawings and files to bring

Print the master plan at 36 × 24 in, and send the PDF and DXF ahead of the meeting. All sheets are revision R4.2 (18 Oct 2026). The boundary on every sheet follows the recorded lines of the four parcels. The alternative layout (halls north, shops south) is on sheets ALT-1 to ALT-3 in a separate PDF.

Sheet	Title	Use in the meeting
C-1	Existing conditions and parcel verification	Parcels, flood layer, excluded neighbors, former quick-lube pad
C-2	Proposed master site plan	Where each use sits on the site
A-1	Proposed building division plan	Floor areas, hall rooms, existing columns
A-2	Event operations	How Hall A and Hall B run separately or together
C-3	Parking and vehicle circulation	Arrivals, parking, service and fire access
C-4	Fuel and convenience-store test	F1 and F2 fuel layouts
A-3	Preliminary architectural improvements	New entrances inside the existing shell

Sheet	Title	Use in the meeting
F-1	Space allocation, budget ranges and phasing	Area budget by use, cost ranges and phases
ALT-1 to ALT-3	Alternative layout: halls north, shops south (separate PDF)	Compare arrivals, parking, flood exposure and the residential edge against the R4.2 layout

Also bring:

- Sycamore_Square_Master_Plan_R4.2.pdf (the eight sheets above)
- Sycamore_Square_Alternative_Layout_Halls_North.pdf (sheets ALT-1 to ALT-3: halls north, shops south)
- Sycamore_Square_Georeferenced_R4.2.dxf (CAD, Tennessee State Plane coordinates, EPSG:2274)
- The 1997 Sitel tenant plans, sheets A2.1 and A2.2
- Sycamore_Square_Legal_and_Regulatory_Findings.pdf
- This package, printed, with room to write the City's answers next to each question

Next steps

Order the elevation certificate and survey first: the flood answer sets the budget, and every other engineer needs the survey. The property is offered by online auction on 2–4 Nov 2026 and is sold as-is, so the survey, elevation certificate, Phase I and City answers should all be in hand before any binding commitment. Start all four now.

1. Send this package and the PDFs to two or three civil engineering firms that work in Memphis, and ask each for a fee proposal for the reviews above.
2. Order the ALTA survey with topography and an elevation certificate now, for delivery before any binding commitment. Order the Phase I environmental assessment the same day.
3. Ask a structural engineer to walk the building in the next few days: confirm the roof framing, the column and footing sizes and the clear height in both halls, and price removing the four interior columns.
4. Ask DPD now for a pre-application meeting, naming the departments listed above. Send the drawings at least a week ahead.
5. Hold the meeting. Write the City's answer next to each question, and ask staff to confirm the notes by email.
6. Request the written zoning verification letters and the floodplain administrator's method for the 50% test now, without waiting for the meeting.
7. Bring the survey, flood answer, City answers and engineering review together into revision R5 of the plans, and update both feasibility studies with real costs.
8. Decide whether to proceed only once the survey, flood, City and engineering answers are in hand.

Sources

- City of Memphis Engineering, 2025 Standards and Guidelines (currently unpublished on the City site). Detention for projects of one acre or more, curb-cut permits, and the finished-floor note of 24 inches above BFE under UDC 8.8.
- Memphis and Shelby County application process (UDC Chapter 9 summary, MTAS). Application types, Land Use Control Board review and notice periods.
- Shelby County, Administrative Site Plan Review. The administrative site plan route.

- 44 CFR 59.1, NFIP definitions. Definition of substantial improvement.
- 44 CFR 65.5, map revisions with no change to base flood elevations. A LOMA compares the lowest adjacent grade with the BFE.
- FEMA National Flood Hazard Layer, queried 18 Oct 2026. FIRM panel 47157C0311G (effective 6 Feb 2013), Zone AE from Fletcher Creek, 248 ft BFE lines, no floodway on the site.
- USGS Elevation Point Query Service (EPQS). 1 m lidar (2017) ground elevations around the building.
- Shelby County Assessor, 2026 record for parcel 088066 00027. Acreage, building area (125,235 SF), year built, class and grade; parcels 00020, 00021 and 00024 have their own assessor records.
- Land Use Control Board staff report S 15-012 (Aug 2015). Fletcher Creek basin and overlay; "Detention is mandatory"; floors 30 inches above the 100-year flood elevation.
- Land Use Control Board staff report P.D. 21-22 (Jul 2021). Sensitive drainage basin (Fletcher Creek), on-site detention, and the overlay's 30-inch floor rule.
- Auction teaser (updated). Online auction 2–4 Nov 2026, 0% occupied, four parcels, 11.72 ac, 909 spaces.
- TDOT, Summer Avenue widening project (5 Jun 2025). Near I-40 to east of Sycamore View, Fletcher Creek bridge replaced, completion due 30 Jun 2028.
- Building permits at 1717 Sycamore View Rd (Property Reports). Demolition permit DEM-24-000379, 31 Oct 2024: building, foundation and footings; final.
- Shelby County ReGIS parcel, zoning, planimetric and flood layers, queried 17 Oct 2026; 1997 Sitel tenant plans A2.1 and A2.2; earlier offering memorandum.
- STRUCTURE magazine, 2021 IBC significant structural changes. Risk Category III for large assembly occupancies, which can trigger seismic upgrades on a change of occupancy.
- USGS, Memphis urban seismic hazard maps. Seismic hazard for the Memphis area near the New Madrid seismic zone.
- Column-removal precedents: Tulsa WeStreet Ice Center (Modern Steel Construction, June 2024), Christ Church of Northwest Arkansas (MBL Architects), Chelsea Piers Connecticut (WSP) and Eagle Brook Church, Anoka (BWBR).

Public version: prices, fees and transaction terms are omitted. Everything here comes from public records, desk research and concept drawings; it is not legal, engineering or investment advice.